Tell the Black Girls We Believe in Their Magic

By Lamont Lilly and Jasmine Mans

tell the black girls by Lamont Lilly

tell the black girls

we believe in their magic.

tell the black girls

how they were born

from a long tradition

of black woman dream merchants

miracle makers

and super heroes.

tell the black girls

how special powers

are interwoven

in their braids and cornrows.

god gifted

in the tips

4NG Fanatics

of their twists and locs.

tell the black girls

how the others

can only dream

and imagine their powers.

tell the black girls

we believe in their magic

and it's real.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lamont Lilly
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
Website:
https://www.newblackmaninexile.net/2016/05/tell-black-girls-and-other-poems-by.html
Publisher: New Black Man In Exile.net
Date (Month/Year): May 6, 2016

****Website Notes poem was to be published in Honor in the Ghetto (Fall 2016) – Cannot confirm publication***

INTRODUCTION

Today I pay tribute to 2 amazing black women through the poetic lens of Jasmine Mans: Serena Williams and Michelle Obama. Believe in their magic . . . for it is real.

Since her tennis debut in 1995, Serena Williams has won 23-time grand slam singles, four Olympic gold medals and is considered one of the greatest athletes of all time. Williams and her career have meant so much to me because she is and has always been unapologetically Black. In a world that often makes it seem as though Blackness and success are mutually exclusive; she is a shining example of what is possible. Of course, her success didn't shield her from racism – in fact, she refused to play in one tournament after receiving a ton of racial abuse from the crowd in 2011. But the way she handled the prejudice levelled at her taught me an invaluable lesson. Racism can be a footnote in an epic story of achievement – not a main theme or chapter. Serena Williams is and will forever be one of the most influential Black women on the planet.

Serena by Jasmine Mans (Pg 190-193)

They will ask you to run,

and when you become the fastest

they will fear your lightning,

how it cracks ceilings and breaks

ground. They will place rules on your

body, say it's a distraction from

their game,

as if they know better than you

how your bones should wear your own body,

how you should dress up in your own skin.

4NG Fanatics

They don't know why your hair

needs extra bobby pins, or how you got the

biggest booty in tennis,

something about Compton and collard greens. They will

not be graceful with your body,

but you will always have to be.

When they put you against

your own sister,

she'll sharpen you.

Passersby will attack your

character,

Serena smashes racket,

point penalty,

violation,

how will she ever come back from this one,

she is too aggressive,

she has gone too far with her

clothing, how can Serena possibly regroup

from this, fight back,

women do not yell, women do not take

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

their shirts off, Serena loses the match and is fined
$17,000,
we cannot allow her to get too out of control.
Women are not allowed real emotion
in tennis,
in the street,
in the office,
In their skin.
Serena, lean in
more power, use more power,
backhand,
back!
Backhand, Serena!
More! More follow through!!
Take the net, Serena,
be tuff,
be tuff.

Act like you want to win.
Forward!
Forward!
Back,

4NG Fanatics

back,
back,

you got this Serena,
net,
net

net, Serena,
yes!
Power, Serena,
play to win!!
What does it feel like
to prepare your body for the
US Open,
Australian Open,
to be cut open.
And to still give them grace,
even when they call you names,
even when they paint your face,
you give them grace.

Without fear, doubt, or discomfort,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

what else is there to overcome?

You're sport,

not spectacle,

woman before

competitor

When they walk

You fly

when they grunt,

you roar.

You are a fire

catching its breath.

You embrace failure,

never run from it.

We've already

watched you defy

gravity

but today,

today, you will become it.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jasmine Mans
Book: Black Girl, Call Home, Pg 190-193
ISBN: 978-0593197141
Publisher: Berkley
Date (Month/Year): March 2021

TRANSITION

*Tell the Black girls . . . And perhaps no one spoke to our hearts more clearly than First Lady Michelle Obama when she talked about the universal challenges that black women face every day: ". . . there are voices that tell you that you're not good enough. That you have to look a certain way, act a certain way. If you speak up, you're too loud, if you step up to lead, you're being bossy. But I decided I wasn't bossy. I was strong. I wasn't loud. I was a young woman with something important to say." **

What makes us diverse isn't something to diminish, but to celebrate.

Dear First Lady *(for Michelle Obama)* (Pg 194-197)

Dear First Lady,

I watched as my 4-year old cousin,

as she sat in the mirror,

placed my grandmother's pearls

around her neck and said,

“Do I look like Michelle Obama?”

This little girl
who does not know how to say
Rice Krispies or macaroni and cheese,
properly said your name
as if it existed in her long list of heroes
in between Snow White and Santa Claus.

My little cousin does not know Jim Crow.
How to interpret the Constitution
or fight for human rights,
she does not know your views
on health care reform,
your Princeton education,
nor can she point to Chicago on a map.

But she knows Black Barbie dolls and nap time,
how to identify your face in a land-field
of misrepresented women
who share our skin color
like a sequin revolution.

4NG Fanatics

She knows your smile, Michelle,
she knows the day
her mother jumped up and down
crying,
November 4th’s
black and red dresses,
how to say how to say
“African American”
better than her own first name.

You proved that her identity belongs
somewhere in this American dream.
She knows that if she can find your face
in the jumbled channels on television
there’s a possibility she can stay up
past her bedtime.

You are everything
her mother never got the chance to be,
Cover Girl’s Beauty of the Week,
a love story sprinkled
in an inaugural speech,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

a woman
she can mistake for her mommy.

She traded in her Dora the Explorer costume
for a brooch of the American flag,
and a tee shirt with your husband's face on it.

And for the first time
I could identify the revolution
that would actually change the world.
And it's not in how many Barack and Martin
comparisons we can make,
but the idea of little boys
jumping off their bunk beds
actually believing that they can fly.

It's in little girls with dreams
and their grandmother's pearls.
My little cousin doesn't know
about the war in Iraq,
she just wonders if Sasha and Malia
like to Hula-Hoop

4NG Fanatics

and if you force them to eat
their Flintstones vitamins too.

Thank you for being
a brown girl's dream come true,
something tangible to look up to.

I know that our skin color
exists on time lines
of women who had craters
engraved in their backs.

Stretch marks similar to maps
of underground railroads.
Grandmothers who couldn't afford
all the ingredients to the American pie.

Women who laid down their lives,
strutted with chips and cracks
in their spines,
dying to inject more estrogen
in "man's kind."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Creating tradition under the idea

that if I can't afford my daughter the world,

a college degree,

or at least, a decent meal tonight.

I'll wrap my grandmother's pearls

around her neck

like a gravity-stricken halo

and I'll whisper in her ear

"Baby,

if I can't,

you will . . .

. . . she did."

***(From the 1st poem)**

tell the black girls

we believe in their magic

and it's real.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jasmine Mans
Book: Black Girl, Call Home, Pg 194-197
ISBN: 978-0593197141
Publisher: Berkley
Date (Month/Year): March 2021

***Transition Quote Source**

Remarks by the First Lady at BET's "Black Girls Rock!" Event, March 28, 2015, New Jersey Performing Arts Center, Newark, New Jersey
https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/2015/03/28/remarks-first-lady-bets-black-girls-rock-event

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY